

Meridian & Associates LLP

Global Professional Services

Code of Conduct and Business Ethics

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Meridian & Associates LLP

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1. A Message from Our Global Managing Partner

Our reputation is our most valuable asset. Every interaction, every engagement, every decision made by any Meridian professional reflects on the entire firm. This Code of Conduct is not merely a compliance document -- it is a statement of who we are and how we choose to operate. It applies to every partner, employee, contractor, and anyone acting on behalf of Meridian & Associates LLP.

I expect every professional to read this Code thoroughly, to complete the annual certification, and -- most importantly -- to live these principles every day. When in doubt, ask. When you see something that does not align with our values, speak up. Our culture depends on it.

2. Anti-Bribery and Anti-Corruption

Meridian maintains a zero-tolerance policy toward bribery and corruption in all forms. We comply with the U.S. Foreign Corrupt Practices Act (FCPA), the UK Bribery Act 2010, and all applicable local anti-corruption laws in every jurisdiction where we operate.

- No Meridian professional may offer, promise, authorize, or pay any bribe, kickback, or improper payment to any person -- including government officials, clients, or private parties.
- Facilitating payments ('grease payments') are prohibited without exception, regardless of local custom or practice.
- All third-party agents, intermediaries, and joint venture partners must undergo anti-corruption due diligence and agree to Meridian's Anti-Corruption Compliance Addendum.
- Political contributions on behalf of the firm are prohibited. Personal political contributions are permitted but must be disclosed if they involve officials connected to firm clients.
- Annual FCPA/anti-corruption training is mandatory for all professionals. Completion rate in FY2025: 99.4%.

3. Gifts, Entertainment, and Hospitality

Meridian recognizes that modest gifts and business hospitality are a normal part of professional relationships. However, they must never create an actual or perceived obligation or conflict.

- Receiving Gifts: Maximum value of \$150 per item; \$500 aggregate per source per calendar year. Cash and cash equivalents (gift cards, vouchers) are never permitted.
- Giving Gifts: Maximum value of \$250 per item. Must be appropriate to the business context and compliant with the recipient's own policies.
- Entertainment: Business meals and events up to \$300 per person are pre-approved. Events exceeding \$300 per person require Ethics Office approval.
- Government Officials: Any gift or hospitality involving a government official or public sector client requires prior written approval from the Ethics Office regardless of value.
- Reporting: All gifts and entertainment exceeding \$75 must be logged in the firm's Gift and Entertainment Registry within 5 business days.

4. Conflicts of Interest

All Meridian professionals have a duty to avoid situations where personal interests could conflict, or appear to conflict, with the interests of the firm or our clients.

- Independence: Professionals on assurance engagements must comply with all applicable independence rules (AICPA, IESBA, SEC where applicable).
- Financial Interests: Professionals may not hold material financial interests in clients they serve or that the firm audits. All investment holdings are subject to annual disclosure and screening via the firm's Independence Compliance System.
- Outside Employment: Any outside employment, board membership, or advisory role requires prior written approval from the professional's service line leader and the Ethics Office.
- Personal Relationships: Professionals must disclose any close personal relationship with a client employee who is in a position to influence the engagement.
- Annual Disclosure: All professionals at the Senior Consultant level and above must complete an annual Conflict of Interest Disclosure questionnaire.

5. Confidentiality and Information Barriers

Protecting client and firm confidential information is a fundamental obligation of every Meridian professional.

- Client information may only be used for the purpose for which it was provided and may not be shared with other clients, engagement teams, or external parties without explicit authorization.
- Information barriers ('ethical walls') are established when the firm serves clients with competing interests or when regulatory requirements mandate separation. Barrier compliance is monitored by the Conflicts Office.
- Clean desk and clear screen policies apply in all offices. Confidential documents must be secured when unattended.
- Use of client information in proposals, case studies, or marketing materials requires prior written consent from the client.
- Non-disclosure obligations survive engagement termination indefinitely unless a shorter period is specified in the engagement agreement.

6. Whistleblower Protection and Reporting

Meridian encourages all professionals and external stakeholders to report concerns about unethical or illegal conduct without fear of retaliation.

- Ethics Hotline: Available 24/7 in 18 languages via phone (1-800-555-ETHX) and web (ethics.meridianllp.com). Operated by an independent third party (NAVEX Global).
- Anonymous Reporting: Reports may be made anonymously. The firm will investigate all credible reports regardless of whether the reporter identifies themselves.
- Non-Retaliation: Meridian strictly prohibits retaliation against anyone who reports a concern in good faith. Retaliation is itself a terminable offense.
- Investigation Process: All reports are reviewed by the Ethics & Compliance team within 48 hours. Investigations are conducted by trained investigators independent of the business unit involved. Findings are reported to the Ethics

Committee.

- In FY2025, the Ethics Hotline received 312 reports. 100% were investigated; 67% were substantiated and resulted in remedial action.

7. Fair Competition and Antitrust

- Meridian competes vigorously but fairly in all markets. Agreements or understandings with competitors regarding pricing, market allocation, or bid rigging are strictly prohibited.
- Professionals must not exchange competitively sensitive information with competitors, whether in formal settings or informal conversations (e.g., industry conferences, social events).
- All professional association memberships and competitor interactions must be conducted in accordance with the firm's Antitrust Compliance Guidelines.

8. Social Media and Public Statements

- Only authorized spokespersons may make statements on behalf of Meridian to the media, analysts, or at public events.
- Personal social media use must not disclose confidential firm or client information, express views that could be attributed to the firm, or disparage clients, competitors, or colleagues.
- Professionals are encouraged to build their professional brand on platforms like LinkedIn but must identify views as their own and not those of Meridian.
- All thought leadership content (articles, blog posts, white papers) must be reviewed by the Communications team before publication.

9. Workplace Conduct and Anti-Harassment

Meridian is committed to providing a workplace free from harassment, discrimination, and bullying of any kind. This applies to all interactions -- in-office, virtual, at client sites, and at firm-sponsored events.

- Zero tolerance for harassment based on race, color, religion, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity, national origin, disability, age, veteran status, or any other protected characteristic.
- All complaints are investigated promptly and thoroughly. Substantiated harassment results in disciplinary action up to and including termination.
- Mandatory anti-harassment training annually for all professionals; enhanced training for managers and partners.

10. Responsible AI and Technology Ethics

As Meridian increasingly deploys artificial intelligence and generative AI (GenAI) tools in client engagements and internal operations, every professional must understand their responsibilities regarding the ethical use of these technologies.

- Permitted uses of GenAI: Research assistance, first-draft document generation, code development support, data analysis acceleration, and internal knowledge retrieval -- provided outputs are reviewed by a qualified human before delivery to clients or use in decision-making.

- Prohibited uses of GenAI: Inputting client confidential data into unapproved AI tools; using AI outputs as final work product without human review; relying on AI for audit opinions, legal advice, or regulatory filings without expert validation; using AI to generate misleading or fabricated content.
- Approved tools only: Professionals may only use AI tools that have been vetted and approved by the AI Governance Board (see the Approved AI Tools Registry on the firm intranet). Use of personal AI accounts (e.g., personal ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude accounts) for firm or client work is strictly prohibited.
- Transparency: When AI tools contribute materially to a client deliverable, this must be disclosed to the engagement partner and documented in the engagement file. Client consent is required where engagement terms mandate it.
- Bias awareness: All professionals using AI-assisted analytics or decision-support tools must complete the firm's Responsible AI Foundations training (mandatory annually) and must critically evaluate AI outputs for potential bias, hallucination, or error.

11. Personal Data Handling Responsibilities

Every Meridian professional handles personal data in the course of their work -- whether client data, employee data, or third-party data. The following obligations apply to all staff regardless of role or seniority:

- Need-to-know access: Only access personal data that is necessary for your specific role and current engagement. Do not browse, copy, or retain personal data beyond what is required.
- Secure handling: Personal data must be stored only in approved firm systems (never on personal devices, personal cloud storage, or USB drives). Encryption is mandatory for any transfer.
- Incident reporting: Any suspected or actual loss, theft, unauthorized access, or accidental disclosure of personal data must be reported to the Privacy Incident Response Team (PIRT) within 1 hour of discovery. Failure to report is itself a disciplinary matter.
- Retention and disposal: Follow the firm's Data Retention Schedule. Do not retain personal data beyond the approved period. Use approved disposal methods (cryptographic erasure, cross-cut shredding).
- Cross-border awareness: Before transferring personal data across national borders, confirm that an approved transfer mechanism is in place (SCCs, BCRs, adequacy decision). Contact the Privacy Office if uncertain.
- Training: Annual Data Privacy and Protection training is mandatory for all staff. Role-specific modules apply to HR, recruitment, and client-facing data analysts.

12. Insider Trading and MNPI

In the course of serving clients, Meridian professionals may become aware of material nonpublic information (MNPI) -- information that, if made public, could affect the price of a client's securities. The misuse of MNPI is a serious criminal offense.

- Trading prohibition: No Meridian professional may trade in the securities of any company while in possession of MNPI about that company, regardless of how the information was obtained.
- Tipping prohibition: Passing MNPI to any other person -- including family members, friends, or colleagues not authorized to receive it -- is strictly prohibited (known as 'tipping').
- Restricted list: The Conflicts Office maintains a Restricted Securities List. Professionals must check this list and obtain pre-clearance before executing any personal securities trade.
- Information barriers: When the firm is engaged on transactions involving publicly traded securities (M&A, IPO advisory, due diligence), strict information barriers are established and monitored. Unauthorized disclosure across

barriers is a terminable offense.

- Monitoring: The firm conducts automated surveillance of employee trading activity via its Independence Compliance System and reports anomalies to the Ethics Office.
- Training: Annual Insider Trading and MNPI training is mandatory for all professionals at the Consultant level and above. Enhanced training for professionals in M&A advisory, due diligence, and financial services engagements.

13. Modern Slavery Awareness

Meridian is committed to preventing modern slavery and human trafficking in all its forms across our operations and supply chain, in accordance with the UK Modern Slavery Act 2015 and the Australian Modern Slavery Act 2018.

- Awareness obligation: Every professional must be alert to indicators of forced labor, debt bondage, human trafficking, and exploitative working conditions -- whether encountered in our supply chain, at client sites, or in the communities where we operate.
- Reporting: Any suspicion of modern slavery must be reported immediately via the Ethics Hotline or directly to the General Counsel's office. Reports may be made anonymously.
- Supply chain vigilance: Professionals involved in procurement decisions must ensure that the firm's Supplier Code of Conduct (which includes anti-slavery provisions) is incorporated into all new contracts and renewals above \$100,000.
- Training: All professionals in procurement, HR, and facilities management roles must complete annual Modern Slavery Awareness training. General awareness is included in the annual Code of Conduct certification for all staff.
- Annual statement: Meridian publishes a Modern Slavery Statement annually, signed by the Global Managing Partner, detailing the steps taken to assess and mitigate modern slavery risks.

14. Disciplinary Framework

Violations of this Code are taken seriously and addressed through a graduated disciplinary framework:

- Level 1 -- Coaching and Counseling: For minor or first-time infractions. Documented in personnel file.
- Level 2 -- Formal Written Warning: For repeated minor infractions or moderate violations. May impact performance rating and compensation.
- Level 3 -- Suspension and Investigation: For serious violations. Professional placed on administrative leave pending investigation.
- Level 4 -- Termination: For egregious violations including fraud, bribery, sexual harassment, data breach caused by willful misconduct, or patterns of repeated violations.
- All disciplinary actions are reviewed by the Ethics Committee for consistency and fairness.